

Hormonal therapy

Some cancers depend on hormones to grow. Find out about different hormonal therapies and how they work.

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What are hormones?

Hormones are substances produced naturally in the body. They help control how cells grow and what they do in the body.

Hormones are produced by a number of different organs and glands. Together, these are known as the endocrine system. Hormonal therapy is sometimes called endocrine therapy.

What is hormonal therapy?

Hormonal therapies work by changing the production or activity of particular hormones in the body. They are most commonly used to treat [breast cancer](#) and [prostate cancer](#). The type of hormone therapy you have depends on the type of cancer being treated.

You can read more in the treatment section for the type of cancer you have:

- [hormonal therapy for breast cancer](#)
- [hormonal therapy for breast cancer in men](#)
- [hormonal therapy for DCIS](#)
- [hormonal therapy for secondary breast cancer](#)
- [hormonal therapy for prostate cancer](#)
- [hormonal therapy for advanced prostate cancer](#)
- [hormonal therapy for womb cancer](#)

Our section about [cancer drug treatments](#) has more general information that you may find helpful.

There are several different types of hormone therapy. People usually have it as either tablets or injections.

Side effects of hormonal therapy

Side effects of hormonal therapies will vary and depend on the individual drug. General side effects can include:

- [tiredness \(fatigue\)](#)
- headaches
- [feeling sick \(nausea\)](#)
- muscle or joint aches.

Some people have:

- [hot flushes](#)
- a lowered sex-drive
- erectile dysfunction.

We have more detailed information about particular [treatments or drugs](#).

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our hormonal therapy information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

ESMO. Early breast cancer clinical practice guidelines for diagnosis, treatment and follow-up. 2019, Vol 30, pp1192–1220. Available from: <https://www.esmo.org/guidelines/guidelines-by-topic/breast-cancer/early-breast-cancer> [accessed 2024].

National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE). Early and locally advanced breast cancer: diagnosis and management. 2018. Updated 2023. Available from: <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/ng101> [accessed 2024].

National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE). Prostate cancer: diagnosis and management. 2019. Updated 2021. Available from [Recommendations | Prostate cancer: diagnosis and management | Guidance | NICE](#) (accessed 2024).

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ⓘ This content is currently being reviewed. New information will be coming soon.

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help